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HEADQUARTERS
UNITED STATES MILITARY ASSISTANCE COMMAND, VIETNAM
Office of Information
APO US FORCES 96243

MACOI

FLWG IS THE OFFICIAL MACV COMMUNIQUE #080-66 AS OF 1700H
21 MAR 1966:

The only significant ground action reported during the 24-hour period was in the Northern Provinces. A multi-company US Marine unit in Operation Oregon were reported in contact with an estimated VC company, 15 miles northwest of Hue, yesterday afternoon. By dark, 14 VC had been killed by the Marines. During the night sporadic contact was continued and Marines were reported in heavy contact late this morning.

In air action over the Republic, B-52 bombers struck a VC position in support of Operation Silver City early this morning. Combat pilots flew a total of 356 sorties against the VC. Air Force pilots logged 163, Navy pilots added 101 and Marine jets flew 92.

Offshore, the destroyer USS Sproston fired a support mission in II Corps yesterday, hitting a VC troop concentration. Spotter reported several secondary explosions.

Meanwhile, Navy and Coast Guard units on Market Time patrols checked 651 vessels, detaining one junk and 11 persons.

North of the 17th parallel, US pilots flew 45 missions against military and communications targets.

Two US Navy aircraft were lost over North Vietnam yesterday--an A4 Skyhawk and an F4 Phantom. The pilot of the A4 ejected but rescue efforts failed to pick him up. The pilot of the F4 was rescued but his radar officer is missing in action.

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UNITED STATES MILITARY ASSISTANCE COMMAND, VIETNAM

Office of Information (MACOI)
APO US Forces 96243

RELEASE NO: 080-66

SAIGON, MONDAY
21 MARCH 1966--1700H

RELEASED THIS DATE:

1. The 7th Fleet destroyer USS Sproston provided gunfire support in the II Corps area of the Republic yesterday.

Sproston fired 194 rounds of five-inch ammunition at VC troop concentrations. Spotters reported several secondary explosions, and excellent target coverage overall.

2. US Navy ships and Coast Guard units in Operation Market Time inspected 221 vessels and boarded and searched 430 for a total of 651 during the reporting period. One junk was detained and 11 persons were held for further interrogation.

3. US Air Force B-52 crews struck Viet Cong positions in support of Operation Silver City in War Zone "D" about 35 miles north-northeast of Saigon early this morning.

4. In air action over North Vietnam yesterday, U.S. Air Force pilots

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flew 24 armed route reconnaissance missions, encountering light to moderate anti-aircraft and automatic weapons fire over some targets. Pilots reported the weather as overcast with thundershowers during the afternoon and clear, but with haze and ground fog in the early evening.

Targets hit and bomb damage assessment in relation to Dien Bien Phu were: Highway bridge, 64 miles east; cratered eastern approach and possible damage to bridge. Warehouse type structures, 6 miles south; two structures damaged. Three barges, 6 miles south; two barges damaged. Military radio transmitter site, 28 miles northeast; damage to three buildings and three antenna masts. Supplies on road, 37 miles east; supplies damaged.

In relation to Hanoi: Highway segment, 110 miles northwest; cratered. Highway bridge, 94 miles northwest; destroyed. Som Tra railroad yard, 90 miles northwest; three cuts, one at each end and one in the center. Also depot buildings damaged. Trucks and possible POL on Route 6, 82 miles west; one truck destroyed and secondary explosion with fire-balls and heavy black smoke coming from suspected POL area.

In relation to Vinh: Highway segment, 65 miles south; cut and cratered. Highway segment, 60 miles south; cratered in three places and cut in two places

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by large landslides. Highway bridge, 60 miles south; destroyed and road cut in three places. Highway bridge, 56 miles south; destroyed. Five trucks on road, 71 miles southeast; heavy damage to trucks.

5. 21 MAR -- US strike pilots flew 356 combat sorties--163 Air Force, 92 Marine and 101 Navy sorties launched from the carrier USS Ticonderoga in all four Corps areas of the Republic yesterday. Principal targets were enemy river shipping, base camps, training sites, troop concentrations, fortifications and supply and storage areas.

In I Corps, strike pilots flew 90 strike sorties, 86 Marine and four Air Force. FACs reported sighting four secondary explosions during the attacks and three VC were possibly killed by the air attacks. A majority of the Marine sorties were flown in close support of Marine ground operations.

In II Corps, pilots flew 88 sorties -- 65 Air Force, 17 Navy and six Marine. During the strikes, two secondary explosions were observed in addition to numerous buildings being destroyed or damaged. FACs directing the air strikes reported receiving moderate to intense small arms fire.

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In III Corps, pilots flew 102 sorties, 67 Air Force and 35 Navy. Besides destroying several enemy buildings, eight sampans were reported destroyed and three enemy were possibly killed. One secondary explosion was also observed.

In IV Corps, pilots flew 76 sorties, 49 Navy and 27 Air Force. Eleven VC were possibly killed during the strikes. Eight enemy sampans were destroyed and two secondary explosions were sighted in other air strikes throughout the III Corps area.

During the night Air Force pilots flew 16 flare-drop sorties flying AC47s and C123s and dropping more than 470 flares.

6. US Navy A1, A3, A4, and F4 pilots flew 21 armed route reconnaissance missions in North Vietnam yesterday, encountering intense anti-aircraft and automatic weapons fire on some targets. Weather on targets ranged from clear to heavy overcast. The planes were launched from the USS Ranger and USS Enterprise.

Two aircraft from the USS Enterprise were lost over North Vietnam yesterday. An A4 was lost about 16 miles southeast of Vinh. The pilot

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successfully ejected but search and rescue efforts failed. The pilot is missing in action.

An F4 Phantom went down along the North Vietnam coast about 28 miles southeast of Vinh. The pilot was picked up by search and rescue forces, but the crewman was not rescued and is listed as missing in action.

Targets hit and damage in relation to Dong Hoi: Wood bridge, 43 miles northwest; approaches heavily cratered. Bridge, 50 miles northwest; cratered approaches. Cargo barges, 40 miles southwest; one damaged. Road segment, 51 miles northwest; cratered. Highway bridge, 42 miles north-northwest; heavily damaged and a highway bridge, 40 miles north-northwest; destroyed.

In relation to Vinh: Tu My highway segment, 16 miles southwest; cratered. Highway bridge, 43 miles south; cratered approaches. Highway bridge on Route 1A, 32 miles southeast; destroyed. Forty-foot cargo junk, 38 miles southeast; damaged. Tu Dung highway ferry landing, 42 miles southeast; cratered east and west approaches. Five barges, 39 miles southeast, area extensively cratered. Road segment, 13 miles southwest; cratered, and 40-foot cargo junk, 23 miles southeast; sunk.

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In relation to Thanh Hoa: 40-foot cargo junk, 10 miles east; damaged and a truck, four miles north; destroyed.

In relation to Hai Phong: One 40-foot cargo junk located 40 miles south-southwest; heavily damaged.

Other targets were hit in relation to Dong Hoi and Vinh with no BDA available due to weather.

7. HQ III MAF DA NANG 21 MAR -- A multi-company force of US Marines from the 4th Marines and 1st Marine Regiments were lifted by helicopter early yesterday afternoon into the rice-rich coastal plains about 15 miles northwest of Hue, in the vicinity of Ap Trung Thanh. The operation has been dubbed "Oregon". Heavy ground fire in the landing zone was suppressed by 11 bombing and strafing sorties by Marine jets prior to the initial assault wave landing.

During the afternoon the Marines were in contact with an estimated VC company, with moderate to heavy fighting reported. Prior to darkness yesterday, the Marine infantry had killed 14 VC while suffering light casualties. Pre-positioned artillery fired in support of the operation.

Sporadic light contact was maintained with the enemy during the night. As of late this morning Marines were again heavily engaged. The enemy was reported to be armed with both heavy automatic weapons and 60mm mortars.

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Additional Marine companies were heli-lifted into the area this morning, making the force multi-battalion in size. The Marine force is called Task Group Foxtrot.

There have been 34 Viet Cong killed in the two days of the operation.

8. An Air Force 01E was downed by enemy ground fire 100 miles northeast of Saigon this morning, killing the pilot and injuring the observer.

9. An Air Force A1E was hit by ground fire while on a mission in support of Operation Garfield Saturday and was forced to land with his landing gear "up" at the Bong Brien airstrip (AQ 7055).

One member of the two-man crew was slightly injured.

10. 21 MAR -- A US Navy A4C was downed while making an airstrike in Go Cong Province (XS 7241) at 1750H yesterday. The pilot is listed as missing.

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11. BINH DINH 21 MAR -- Elements of the 1st Air Cavalry, conducting a search and destroy operation called Operation Jim Bowie, have had no significant contact in the nine days of searching for the enemy.

To date, 14 VC have been killed in scattered light contact, while six VC have been captured and five suspects detained. They have also seized 14 individual weapons.

The operation, in an area about 50 miles northwest of Qui Nhon, has been supported by 139 tactical air sorties. Friendly casualties are light, the majority of them sustained from punji sticks.

12. I FORCE V -- No contact with the Viet Cong was reported by Force I units as of 1400H today.

Yesterday, however, a battalion-sized element of the 1st Brigade, 101st Airborne Division sweeping 12 miles south of Tuy Hoa in dense jungle mountain terrain was reported to have been in, what a brigade spokesman described as heavy contact with an unknown VC force for more than seven hours. The contact was broken by the VC at 2145H last night and this morning the paratroopers found no enemy bodies in the area.

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The fire fight broke out when the 2d Battalion, 502d Infantry ran into a suspected North Vietnam army unit occupying high ground. The battalion deployed and called air and artillery on the enemy positions. Friendly casualties were reported as light.

It is believed that the VC were part of the element that the 101st had been in contact with in the Tuy Hoa area during the earlier days of Operation Harrison.

This morning the 502 found a company-sized base camp in the same area of yesterday's fire fight.

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